Tab 1

Writing about work experience on your CV and application forms

Looking to bulk out your CV with work experience? This blog has you covered with expert advice from our Student Futures team.

Student Futures

People often find that one of the biggest challenges when it comes to writing their CV and filling out application forms is talking about their work experience. This blog will look at what constitutes work experience and how you can talk about it. Although you may not have had a full-time job, it's highly likely that you'll have one or more of the experiences discussed below.

Employment

This can be full-time, part-time or temporary, it covers any type of employment. Always include the name of your employer, your job title and your start and finish dates with the employer. Mention the purpose of the role, your main responsibilities and the skills you used and developed.

Work Placements

You may have undertaken placements while at school or university. Placements can be opportunities to develop your skills, knowledge and experience. Reflect on what you learnt on your placement, particularly the skills and knowledge you gained. Make sure you really emphasise work experience that is directly relevant to what you're applying for. For first hand advice, read Tobias' story on his work placement experience at The Walt Disney Company.

Volunteering

Talk about this as you would for an employed role, emphasising what you did and what you learnt. If you've not got any volunteering experience, it's a good place to start a valuable attribute to employers which they look for when they scan your CV. There are lots of volunteering opportunities available in a range of fields.

Personal Projects

Do you have any hobbies or interests that you have turned into your own personal project? These can help to demonstrate your skills on your applications

Some examples of personal projects you may have worked on might include:

- Building your own website
- Writing a blog
- Taking up photography
- Learning to code
- Writing an e-book

Adding your projects can be even more beneficial if they're related to the job or industry you're applying to. For example, applying for a job in marketing, where the employer ideally would like someone with photography or coding skills.

For more expert advice, our team at Student Futures can support.

Student Futures

Student Futures is a sector leader team of specialists who enable UON students to achieve their personal aspirations and career goals. We support you with gaining work experience and connecting with employers, developing your skills and attributes, and ensuring you have a competitive edge in the job market.

Tab 2

Careers And Employability Service

We understand that university is a new, nervously exciting chapter in a student's life. Your degree is not just an investment, it's a stepping stone to exploring your future career. Our Careers and Employability Service is dedicated to equipping students with the skills to thrive, adapt and innovate in our ever-changing world. By studying with us, you benefit from our service being embedded in your curriculum, providing an extensive range of extra and co-curricular initiatives to enhance your employability and social entrepreneurship skills. Our Careers and Employability Partners utilise the latest data and information to ensure you are developing the skills that employers tell us they are looking for in Graduates. We have created an employability offer that we believe will ensure that our Graduates will stand out from the crowd, are socially responsible, digitally proficient, and highly employable global citizens.

This gives you access to:

- Career support tailored to your needs.
- Access to digital tools, including practice interviews, self-assessments, and personalised CV feedback.
- Opportunities to connect with employers at industry-led events, guest speakers and webinars.
- Real-world experiences and teaching by academic staff, our Careers and Employability Partners, Alumni and Industry Leaders.
- Lifelong careers support for all UON alumni, with access to networking opportunities, recruitment fairs, and expert one-to-one advice.

Careers Coaches

UON peer-to-peer careers! An innovative way of supporting students in working towards achieving their career aspirations. Our dedicated career coach team is here to help their peers in various ways in a relaxed and informal environment, offering students the flexibility of a career drop-in service around other university commitments.

The Career Coaches are a diverse group of Undergraduate and Postgraduate students. They assist their fellow students with various aspects of career preparation, including CV creation, job searching, and interview preparation. A first port of call for students wanting advice and support from someone who can more closely empathise with the student's situation and experience. For those requiring more specialised advice or facing barriers to employment, the Career Coaches can make referrals to a dedicated Careers and Employability Partner for in-depth support.

Students can visit the Student Futures Hub on the ground floor of the Learning Hub for face-to-face support from 10:00 to 16:00, Monday through Friday.

Tab 3

6 employability tips for landing your dream job

Don’t let yourself be haunted by the uncertainty of an undefined career path. Developing a career plan can help you unmask your potential and put steps in place to achieve your ambitions.
David Conway
1. Crafting a Career Costume: Define Your Dream Job

Much like choosing a Halloween costume, your career path should be carefully selected. Start by identifying your passions, skills, and interests. Think of this as your career costume. Take the time to research and understand the job market, so you can tailor your career goals accordingly. Remember, it’s okay to be adventurous and experiment with different career costumes until you find the perfect fit as a graduate.

2. Mastering the Art of Networking: Making Connections

Networking is key for your career and provide career planning inspiration. Attend industry events, join professional organisations, and connect with other alumni or mentors. Networking is about building relationships and seeking guidance from those who have treaded the career path before you. Much like collecting sweets while trick-or-treating, gathering valuable insights and contacts can be just as rewarding and help define plans.

3. Polishing Your CV: Casting the Right Spell

Your CV is your career starter. It’s essential to craft a CV that highlights your skills, experiences, and achievements. Tailor your CV for each job application, emphasising how your skills match the specific job requirements. Don’t forget to include volunteering, any part-time work, and any extracurricular achievement you may have achieved, such as the Changemaker Certificate which are relevant to your desired career. A well-crafted CV can be the starting point that opens the door to your dream job.

4. Conquering the Interview Monster: Confidence is Key

Facing a job interview can feel like confronting a monster under your bed. But with preparation and confidence, you can tame the interview beast. Practice your answers to common interview questions, research the company thoroughly, and be ready to discuss how your skills align with their needs. Dress professionally, exude confidence, and remember to ask questions of your own. Interviews are an opportunity for both sides to see if it's a good fit.

5. Embrace the Power of Continuous Learning: Beware Complacency

Its all about change and transformation, and so should your career be. Stay up-to-date with industry trends, acquire new skills, and consider further education or certifications. Don't become complacent; instead, embrace the spirit of lifelong learning to remain relevant and competitive in your field. For example, are there any LinkedIn Learning Courses which relate to your career goal? Could completing a short course such as 'Learning to code' increase options open to you?

6. Seek Out Scarily Good Professional Information, Advice and Guidance

Don't be afraid to seek support from your careers and employability service. Student Futures offers employability support for life to all UON graduates. As alumni you are welcome to make an appointment with a Career Development Consultant. The appointment can be in person, by Teams or over the phone. Contact studentfutures@northampton.ac.uk if you would like our support.

Don't be frightened of having a career plan. With the right strategies in place and persistence, its possible to navigate around any obstacles to land your dream job. We have loads of support on offer here at Northampton with our dedicated careers and employability team who sit within Student Futures.

Tab 4

The Graduate School

What is the Graduate School?

The Graduate School provides a University-wide framework for training, support, career preparation and administration to help you throughout your postgraduate research degree and early research career, to achieve your potential. You can find more information, including the latest news and forthcoming events on the Graduate School blog.

How to Apply

If you are thinking about research degree study, please see the How to Apply page for application details.

“In my role I visit universities all around the world and I have to say that the support and structures for research students and research supervisors at Northampton are some of the best I’ve seen.” – Hugh Kearns, international expert on researcher development, Flinders University, Adelaide, Australia.

PhD (full and part time) | Practice-based PhDs in the Arts (full and part-time) | MPhil (full and part time)

Our PhD and MPhil programmes are available to study full-time and part-time, both on and off-site. This can be negotiated between you and your supervisory team at interview. Formal supervisory meetings take place once every four weeks for full-time students and once every six weeks for part-time students. Students can use the dedicated Research Student Workspace and the library at Waterside.

PhDs by Means of Published Works (part-time only)

Our PhD by Means of Published Works programme is available to study part-time, both on and off-site. This can be negotiated between you and your supervisory team. Formal supervisory meetings take place once every six weeks.

Students can use the dedicated Research Student Workspace and the library at Waterside.

Doctor of Professional Practice (part-time only)

This inter-professional and multi-disciplinary programme combines facilitated modules and independent research. It provides the platform, opportunity and context for you to make change happen in health and social care. The course is only available on a part time basis and there is a requirement to attend in person for facilitated modules. Applications are open to international applications.

Students can use the dedicated Research Student Workspace and the library at Waterside.

Doctor of Business Administration (part-time only)

The Doctor of Business Administration (DBA) is a professional doctorate with the same status as a PhD. It is the highest qualification available in business and management, designed for senior professionals who wish to advance their careers by developing their academic research and critical thinking skills. The Northampton DBA is a part-time programme that typically runs over four years. The first two years are structured around facilitated modules that provide the foundations for the research project, the main element of the DBA. This research project needs to make a significant contribution to professional practice by developing existing theories and knowledge. Students can use the dedicated Research Student Workspace and the library at Waterside.

A Postgraduate Doctoral Loan

A Postgraduate Doctoral Loan can help with course fees and living costs while you study a postgraduate doctoral course. For more information, please visit the gov.uk/doctoral-loan.

Please see the how to apply page for application details.

Our doctoral study experience

Our postgraduate research experience is a little bit different to other universities. We know that you are competent students and independent learners, but we also know that it's good to have people to help you when you need it. That's why we provide you with student support that's tailored to your research area. We make sure that you have regular meetings with your supervisors and our Postgraduate Research Offices provide drop-in support from our dedicated research support team.

We also run a development programme for supervisors who are new to research degree supervision. It is a validated university postgraduate course and it is delivered as two modules, Workshops and Observation.

Skills development programme

"I just wanted to thank you both for a really good workshop. Lots of knowledge consolidated, clarified and also new!" Postgraduate Research Student on Using Social Media workshop.

Alongside project supervision and subject-related development, you will take part in an extensive Postgraduate Research Skills Development Programme throughout your period of study. The programme is multi-stranded, providing the skills needed to complete a successful degree, as well as those needed to be a proficient researcher after degree study. It includes skills workshops and development activities, such as an annual conference, poster competition and Images of Research event.

Induction

"A really well planned and organised week; I really enjoyed it and I look forward to studying at this university". New research student feedback from Induction week.

You will be given an excellent springboard from which to start your studies through our four day induction programme. This delivers hands-on skills workshops, orientation, an introduction to support systems and sessions where you can meet staff, plus an opportunity to present your research to other students. A Faculty-based induction on the fifth day introduces you to the facilities, development events, staff and other PGRs in your faculty.

How to Apply

If you are thinking about research degree study, please see the How to Apply page for application details.

Tab 5

Navigating the Path to Success: A Guide to Securing Placements and Internships

Unlock success by prioritising placements and internships in the UK job market. Gain hands-on experience, valuable skills, and a competitive edge for your dream career.

Student Futures
In the competitive landscape of today's job market, securing a successful career often requires more than just a degree. Employers are increasingly looking for candidates who possess practical experience and a deep understanding of their field. The pursuit of placements and internships has become a crucial steppingstone for students and recent graduates to gain a competitive edge.

In this blog post, we'll explore the significance of placements and internships, their impact on career development, and effective strategies to secure these valuable opportunities.

The Importance of Placements and Internships:

- Hands-on Experience: Placements and internships provide a unique opportunity to apply theoretical knowledge in a real-world setting. This hands-on experience not only enhances practical skills but also allows individuals to adapt to the dynamics of the professional environment.
- Networking Opportunities: Engaging in placements and internships opens doors to valuable networking opportunities. Building connections with professionals in your field can lead to mentorship, guidance, and even potential job offers in the future.
- Skill Development: Employers value candidates with a diverse skill set. Placements and internships offer a platform for individuals to develop both technical and soft skills, such as communication, teamwork, problem-solving, and time management.
- CV Enhancement: A well-rounded CV is crucial in making a positive impression on potential employers. Placements and internships add weight

to your CV, showcasing practical experience and a proactive approach to professional development.

Here are our top tips to secure a Placements or Internship:

1. Research and Target Companies: Identify companies that align with your career goals and values. Conduct thorough research to understand their work culture, values, and the skills they prioritise in candidates. Tailor your application accordingly.
2. Utilise University Resources: Student Futures have dedicated teams that can help you enhance your CV and interview skills and offer support in finding placements and internships. Attend career fairs, workshops, and networking events organised to connect with potential employers and improve your soft skills.
3. Build a Strong Online Presence: Create a professional LinkedIn profile highlighting your skills, experiences, and aspirations. Engage with industry professionals, join relevant groups, and showcase your expertise through regular posts and updates.
4. Craft a Standout CV and Cover Letter: Tailor your CV and cover letter for each application, emphasising relevant skills and experiences. Use quantifiable achievements to demonstrate your impact in previous roles, showcasing your value to prospective employers.
5. Prepare for Interviews: Our Careers and Employability Service within Student Futures can support you with interview preparation. Practice common interview questions and develop compelling narratives about your experiences. Showcase how your skills align with the company's needs and emphasise your eagerness to contribute to their success.

In conclusion, actively pursuing a placement or internship not only propels personal and professional growth but also positions you as standout candidate, fostering a pathway to a promising and fulfilling career.

Tab 6

Stand out from the crowd with these employability tips

Stand out the crowd and impress employers with these tips and tricks to whether you're applying for an internship, work placement or your dream graduate job.

Employability tips

Here are my top tips and tricks to help you stand out from the crowd and impress employers.

Be professional on social media

Employers often check your online presence before hiring you, so make sure you present yourself as respectful, trustworthy and employable on platforms like Twitter, LinkedIn or Facebook.

CV360 Tool

Upload your CV to the CV360 Tool to our Student Futures Portal. Use the feedback report to enhance your CV and make it a real sparkler!

Use graduate recruitment agencies

They can help you find suitable vacancies, prepare for interviews and negotiate salaries. They also have connections with leading employers who may not advertise their roles elsewhere.

Attend webinars, virtual careers fairs and workshops

These are great opportunities to network with employers, alumni and peers, learn new skills and get advice on your career options. You can also ask questions and show your enthusiasm for the organisations you are interested in.

Volunteer for a good cause and light up someone’s day

Volunteering is a great way to make a difference in your community, develop new skills, meet new people, and enhance your CV. You can choose from a range of opportunities that suit your interests, availability, and goals. At Northampton, we have a dedicated team supporting Students Futures. At Northampton, we have a dedicated team supporting your future. You can come and speak to the Changemaker Team within Student Futures for support.

Do well in your first job

Whether it’s a part-time job, an internship, or a graduate role, make sure you focus on your tasks, ask questions, be organised, take on more responsibility, ask for opportunities and get involved in the wider organisation. You can also find a mentor who can guide you and support you in your career journey.

If you are currently applying for internships, placements or Graduate roles at UON, do get in touch with us and we can support you throughout. Our email is studentfutures@northampton.ac.uk.

Tab 7

Employer Engagement

A valuable part of your university experience is making the most of opportunities to engage with employers. Gaining this industry engagement supports you to:

- Explore your career options; find out about sectors/roles you want to work in and rule out those you don't.
- Develop your knowledge of career paths, working environments and the skills you need for your future.
- Gain experience to add to your CV.
- Enhance your employability skills.
- Put your academic learning into practice.
- Build professional networks

At UON, Student Futures support you to engage with employers in different ways throughout your degree, including:

- Careers events; meet and talk with employers at our annual Student Futures Expo and many other events across the year
- Practical experience; access opportunities to gain valuable experience through paid work, internships, year-long placements, short-term placements, volunteering and work shadowing
- Graduate careers; explore graduate schemes and roles that you can apply for before you finish university
- In-course projects and placements; complete placements, live-briefs and projects working directly with businesses and organisations. This is part of many of our modules at UON
- Employability activities; explore career roles and sectors through activities including site visits, talks and workshops delivered by employers
- Mentoring; gain mentorship from UON alumni and employers through our Professional Mentoring Programme

If you are an employer and would like to engage with our students, email employers@northampton.ac.uk

Tab 8

Mentoring

Student Futures' new Professional Mentoring Programme connects UON students with alumni and professionals, giving participants the opportunity to share experiences and insights, fostering the development of self-confidence and skills.

The mentoring programme is open to undergraduate students who are looking to gain further insight into industry, explore potential career paths, or develop professional skills. Students are paired with professionals to meet online on a one-to-one basis.

Each programme runs for a period of 12 weeks, with a minimum commitment of meeting online at least six times. Participants will be provided with an online training session and resources to fully prepare themselves for the programme.

Benefits of being a mentor

- Develop leadership skills
- Gain new perspectives
- Improve communication skills
- Become an advocate for others
- Support your professional development

If you are interested in becoming a voluntary mentor to support the University of Northampton student community, please complete the online registration form. To discuss this opportunity further please email careermentoring@northampton.ac.uk

Benefits of being a mentee

- Increased confidence
- Develop and expand professional networks
- Skill development
- Career development and planning
- Gain real life advice

If you are an undergraduate student and would like to find out more about mentoring at the University of Northampton, please email careermentoring@northampton.ac.uk

Tab 9

Work experience

At West Northamptonshire Council, it is all about our people. People who are curious, eager to learn, and ready to explore new possibilities.

That is why we created the West Northamptonshire Council Workplace Safari - a unique work experience programme designed to open your mind to the many careers in local government that help our communities thrive.

Discover a different kind of work experience

The Workplace Safari is designed for you if you're in years 10 to 12, offering something very different from traditional work experience.

Instead of spending a week shadowing one team, you become part of a cohort and take a journey through the wide range of careers that make a council work.

Across the programme, you will meet passionate professionals from different services who will share their own career journeys, the skills they use every day, and the pathways that led them there.

It is an opportunity for you to ask questions, try practical activities, and discover careers you may never have considered before - or gain more insight into careers you are already interested in.

Explore the careers behind your community

You will gain insight into a wide variety of roles that keep West Northamptonshire running.

Sessions include different council areas, such as:

- Democratic services and elections

- Legal services
- Project management
- Adult Social Care and social work
- Digital, Technology and Innovation
- Community Development
- Waste and environmental services
- Human Resources
- Libraries, museums and heritage services

Each session is led by experienced managers and professionals who explain what their role involves, the qualifications and skills that are helpful and what a typical career pathway might look like.

Learning beyond the classroom

The Workplace Safari also takes learning out into the community.

You will visit key council locations to see how services operate in the real world, including:

- County Hall, where you can tour the historic courtrooms
- The Museum and Art Gallery, exploring artefacts from local archives
- The Central Library, discovering how libraries support learning and communities

- A tour of town centre regeneration projects to understand how places are designed, developed and improved to better the futures for young people in West Northants

Building confidence and future skills

Alongside career exploration, you'll take part in sessions designed to prepare you for your future.

These include:

- CV and personal statement writing
- 'Presenting with impact', helping you build confidence when speaking and sharing ideas
- Team activities and practical challenges linked to real council work

For you, your parents and teachers

The Workplace Safari provides a structured, safe and engaging work experience that helps you understand the breadth of careers available in local government and the skills that employers value. It supports you in making informed decisions about your future education, training and career pathways.

For schools and parents, it offers reassurance that you are gaining meaningful exposure to the working world while developing confidence, communication skills and an understanding of how public services shape your community.

At West Northamptonshire Council, we believe that the future of our communities depends on the next generation of thinkers, creators and problem-solvers.

The Workplace Safari is one way we open the door to those possibilities - giving you the chance to explore, learn and imagine where your ambitions could take you.

2026 dates and how to apply for the Workplace Safari

Our 2026 Workplace Safari will run from **6 to 10 July** and **13 to 17 July**.

You can apply if you are in school years **10 to 12** and studying at a school **based** in West Northamptonshire.

Email **careers@westnorthants.gov.uk** with the subject line **'Workplace Safari enquiry'**.

In your email, include your:

- full name
- email address
- phone number
- school name
- year group

Places are limited. We will contact you to confirm if you have been offered a place or added to the waiting list.

Ad hoc work experience placements



We may offer a limited number of work experience placements outside the Workplace Safari weeks. These are not guaranteed and depend on service capacity.

To enquire about alternative dates, email **careers@westnorthants.gov.uk**.

Include the following information in your email:

- your name

- contact details
- school name
- year group
- the dates you would like work experience
- up to 3 council service areas you are interested in

We will forward your request to the relevant service areas. They will contact you within **2 weeks** if they can offer you a placement.

Please note: Due to the volume of work experience requests received, we are only able to consider requests from students currently studying at a school or college based in West Northamptonshire.

Tab 10

Advice and guidance

Advice to help choose the right course

Each course has different aims, outcomes and entry requirements. Our course description and more details will help you decide which course is right for you by giving information about:

- the course level
- whether a certificate can be achieved to support your career or personal progression
- details of course entry requirements

Once you have selected a course that you are interested in, click on more details. If you would like further information after reading the course information, a **member of our team** will be pleased to help you.

New courses are added to our website throughout the year, if the ‘find a course’ link does not lead to courses, this means that none are available at that time though new courses will be added in the future. If you would like to receive information from us about our courses, please email **adultlearning@northnorthants.gov.uk**.

Qualification and certificate guidance

If a course is accredited, it means that upon successful completion you will receive a certificate that is recognised by employers and other education providers showing the qualification title and level achieved. The higher the level number, the more difficult the qualification.

After completing your course, your certificate will be sent to you at the earliest opportunity. This may take several months after your course has finished.

To ensure your certificate reaches you safely, it is your responsibility to provide correct personal information. If a certificate is returned to us, we will hold these for a period of 12 months only.

There is a cost to re-printed certificates should you require a change of name or address to a certificate. If there is an admin error on your certificate, such as a name, we will fund the cost of a replacement.

For certificate enquiries, or to notify of change in personal details, please contact us on **adultlearning@northnorthants.gov.uk**.

For more information on **what qualification levels mean: Overview - GOV.UK (www.gov.uk)**.

Support to book onto a course

- **Enrolment**
- **Activate your account**

Advice for your next steps

Our team can help you with:

- finding the right course
- advice about learning to support your progression
- understanding our course fees
- signposting to additional services

For advice and guidance on your next steps in learning, **contact our team**.

The National Careers Service can help you with:

- online tools to help you make decisions about career choices
- personalised careers guidance
- advice about getting a job
- signposting towards specialist resources and support

Wherever you are in your career progression and decision-making, visit the **National Careers Service website** or call **0800 100 900**.

Tab 11

Mainstream Careers Ltd in Northampton offers educational and career-related support and is based at 400 Pavilion Dr, Northampton NN4 7PA.

AS Consulting. Coaching. HR. Career in Northampton advertises CV writing and job interview help, with a focus on employment guidance.

CV Jet in Northampton provides CV services, which can be useful if career advice is specifically about applications and job search materials.

TESS Group in Northampton is mainly a training and apprenticeship provider, but it also sits in the employability/career-development space.

Starting Off in Northampton supports apprenticeships and early-career progression, which makes it useful for students looking for career direction.

Humphrey & Kirk is a recruiter in Northampton that also supports candidates through the job process.

Tate Recruitment Northampton says its local team offers career advice, CV tips, and interview preparation.

Quest Employment Northampton is another local recruitment branch that helps people into work.

Free or public support
National Careers Service is available to people in Northamptonshire and offers impartial advice on careers, CVs, interviews, and choosing a new career.

Northampton College's Futures careers team gives impartial guidance on university, apprenticeships, and job searching, which is especially relevant for students.

West Northamptonshire Council also lists employment support partners, which can help connect people to local advice services.